

monial written about them. A similar feature is provided by orkut, whereby a user can publicly declare them as being a 'fan' of another user without an explanatory message.

Trust Mechanisms

Having a positive reputation or testimonial is a type of trust mechanism, similar to the ratings system employed by eBay where auction transactions completed successfully or unsuccessfully are linked to a person's profile and will often determine whether another user will deal with them or not. In professional sites, this is particularly important if for example five matches are returned while looking for a venture capitalist with two degrees of one's personal network, and no other determination can be made apart from user ratings as to whom to contact.

While an endorsement is also a useful way of determining whether to trust another user or not, some emphasis should be placed on the number of degrees between the endorser and the endorsee to ensure that a person's friends are not the only people extolling their virtues. This does not seem to be a feature of most social networking sites at the moment. "All are equal, but some are more equal than others". The users of a social network can have an elevated perceived status if they are identified in some desirable way, for example as an entertainment celebrity or the founder of a popular community. Some sites such as orkut place emphasis on their users being stars, and use this as an attraction for new members. The success of a community forum can lead to their creators or moderators having a desirable status within that community, since they usually have the power to remove members, edit or delete discussion topics, or even erase the community completely.

A user can also be perceived as a minor celebrity if their network of friends extends into the hundreds. By presenting certain members of the network on special pages and publicizing data on the number of views their profile has received, these persons can have an elevated status. It becomes desirable to know that popular person, and hence to become a member of their network or inner circle.